

feet for some *bhangra*. Her family, some with her in Navi Mumbai and some back home in Delhi, couldn't help but tear up. It would be natural to assume there might be a small drop of regret somewhere in Pratika's bloodstream for not being an active part of that thrilling summit clash.

"I've taken after my mother (Rajni). I am practical. My coach, Deepti Dhyani, is the same, too. They keep telling me that God has his own ways. Whatever happens, happens for good. When you keep hearing that, you don't feel like you're missing out on anything. When the time comes, I'm going to get much more." That foresight comes from the toil and hard choices she had to make early on.

Lessons from early rebellion

She was the first girl to enrol for cricket coaching under Shravan Kumar at Rohtak Road Gymkhana. She has always been a sporty kid, dabbling in athletics before juggling basketball and cricket alongside her academics. She has been in the Under-19 setup since 12. Pratika piled on runs at the age-group and domestic

levels. But there came a time when taking on so much started to affect performance.

"I had practice in the morning for basketball and then training in the evening for cricket, which I balanced with tuitions. I remember there was this U-19 domestic season where I didn't score too many runs. We were playing a match in Guntur in Andhra, and I got out for a duck. We won that game nevertheless, but I remember thinking to myself when I was

fielding then, 'Prats, if you want to play this sport at the highest level, this is not going to work.' I was 16 then when I made that choice, and it was mine to make."

While practical and fairly wise now, thanks largely to the conditioning her support system provided, she was once a tantrum-throwing *shaitaan* (devil), as her mother describes. Pratika calls her phase of teenage rebellion her lowest point.

"Teenagers love to defy and not listen to their parents. Same here. I was in the worst possible shape as an athlete. I was eating a lot of junk, going late for practice, and not studying well. I love to be in control, usually, but I had lost that control over my life.

"There was another instance when I was 14. I was not selected for one of the National teams in basketball despite playing well. It broke my heart. I threw a tantrum with my mom, saying I deserved it, and maybe I didn't get selected



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

I REMEMBER MY MOM CALLING ME. SHE CAN'T STAY UP LATE, BUT SHE DID THAT DAY. DAD ASKED HER WHY SHE WAS STILL AWAKE, AND SHE SAID, 'MY DAUGHTER HAS WON THE COUNTRY A WORLD CUP. HOW CAN I SLEEP?'